



40 FIT PROBLEMS · 2 FIXES EACH

The **Fit-Fix** Library

The 40 most common fit problems — what you see, why it happens, how to fix the garment you already sewed and how to change the paper pattern so it never happens again.

- ✓ Neckline, shoulders, bust, back, waist, hips, sleeves, pants, hems
- ✓ Fix on the finished garment + fix on the paper pattern
- ✓ A simple diagram for every pattern change
- ✓ cm and inches everywhere

How to use this library

Every fit problem leaves a signature: drag lines point to the place that is too tight, folds collect where there is too much fabric. Find the signature, find the fix.

1. **Try it on inside out** (so you can pin) with the underwear and shoes you'll wear with it. Stand naturally, then reach, sit and walk.
2. **Take 3 photos** — front, side, back — and compare the drag lines with the "What you see" line of each fix.
3. **Fix the top first:** shoulders → bust → back → waist → hips → hem. A shoulder fix often solves a "bust" problem.
4. **Pin out excess** (folds) or **open seams** (pulls) and measure the amount in cm / inches. That number is what you move on the paper pattern.
5. **Change the paper pattern** before your next garment and make a quick muslin (cheap cotton) of the bodice or the pants. Write the change on the pattern piece with the date.

 paper added (spread)  paper removed (overlap / fold) - - - slash line  new cutting line

Golden rules. Seam allowance in The Sewing Pattern Bible is 1.5 cm / 5/8 in on wovens and 1 cm / 3/8 in on knits — that allowance is what you can let out. Every change on the front usually needs the matching change on the back, facings and linings. Always "true" seams after a change: walk the two seam lines against each other so they're the same length and meet at a right angle at hems and necklines.

Choose the right size first. Tops & dresses: choose by bust (full bust over a B cup → choose by upper bust + 5 cm / 2 in and do an FBA — Fix 9). Skirts & pants: choose by hips, then adjust the waist (Fix 20). Between two sizes → blend: trace the smaller size at the shoulders/waist and the larger at the bust/hips, curving smoothly between. Your coach can do this math for you — just give it your measurements.

Contents

1. Neckline & Shoulders	Fixes 1–8
2. Bust	Fixes 9–14
3. Back	Fixes 15–19
4. Waist & Hips	Fixes 20–26
5. Sleeves & Armholes	Fixes 27–32
6. Pants	Fixes 33–38
7. Hems & Knit Edges	Fixes 39–40

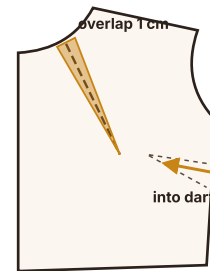
Neckline & Shoulders

Fix the top of the garment first: everything below hangs from the shoulders.

1 Front neckline gapes

What you see: The neckline stands away from your chest and folds over when you lean forward; V-necks and wrap tops show your bra.

Why it happens: There is more fabric length along the front neckline edge than your upper chest needs — very common with a full bust or a hollow upper chest.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Sew a small line of ease-stitch (long stitch 4 mm) along the neckline 3 mm / 1/8 in inside the seam, pull the bobbin thread gently to draw it in 0.5–1 cm / 1/4–3/8 in, steam to shrink.
2. Or unpick the facing/neckband, take a tiny dart (0.5–1 cm deep, 5–6 cm / 2–2 1/4 in long) at the neckline pointing to the bust, then re-attach.
3. For a wrap top: add a hidden snap or a 3–4 cm clear elastic inside the neckline edge.

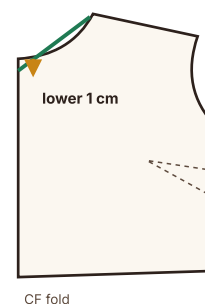
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Pin the gape out on your muslin or garment: it forms a wedge. Measure its depth at the edge (e.g. 1 cm / 3/8 in).
2. On the pattern, draw a line from the neckline to the bust apex. Cut to (not through) the apex.
3. Overlap the neckline edge by the wedge depth; the paper opens up at the bust dart — the extra goes into the dart. True the neckline curve.
4. Do the same on the facing so it matches.

2 Neckline too high or tight

What you see: The neckline presses on your throat, feels choking, or the collar pulls into diagonal folds at the base of the neck.

Why it happens: Your neck base is wider or lower than the pattern's block, or the neckband was cut too short.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the neckband/facing. Trace a new neckline 0.6–1 cm / 1/4–3/8 in lower at the front, blending to 0 at the shoulder.
2. Trim, staystitch the new edge, then re-attach the facing (trim it the same amount) or cut a new, slightly longer neckband (knit: band = 85% of the new opening).

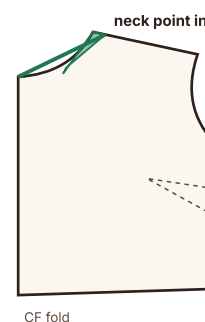
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Lower the front neckline 0.6–1 cm at center front, blend to the shoulder point. If the pull is all around, also scoop the back 0.3–0.5 cm.
2. Redraw the facing to the new line and re-measure the neckband/collar to the new seam length (minus seam allowances).

3 Neckline too wide — bra straps show

What you see: The neckline slides toward your shoulders and your straps peek out, or a boat neck slips off.

Why it happens: Narrow shoulders/neck compared with the pattern, or a stretched neckline edge (not staystitched).



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take a small tuck at each shoulder seam at the neck end only (0.5–1 cm, blending to 0 at the shoulder point), re-attach facing.
2. Add lingerie guards: a 4 cm thread chain + snap on the shoulder seam allowance to hold straps.

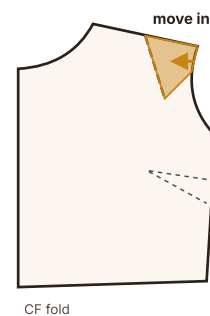
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Move the neck point in along the shoulder line by 0.5–1.5 cm / 1/4–5/8 in on front AND back; redraw the neck curve to the original center front depth.
2. Always staystitch necklines 1.2 cm / 1/2 in from the edge right after cutting.

4 Shoulders too wide

What you see: The shoulder seam falls off your shoulder bone onto your upper arm; the sleeve cap collapses into a dent.

Why it happens: Narrow shoulders — the pattern's shoulder is longer than yours.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Set-in sleeve: unpick the sleeve from the top 1/3 of the armhole, redraw the armhole 1–2 cm / 3/8–3/4 in in from the shoulder point, blend to the original armhole at the notches, trim, reset the sleeve.
2. Sleeveless: unpick the facing/binding at the shoulder and trim the armhole the same way.

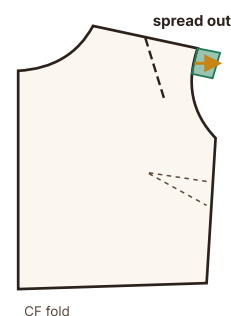
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Draw a line from the middle of the shoulder seam down to the armhole notch (an L-shape to the side).
2. Cut and slide the armhole piece in by the excess (1–2 cm), keeping the armhole curve. Tape. True the shoulder line. Repeat on the back.

5 Shoulders too narrow

What you see: The shoulder seam sits on top of the shoulder but the sleeve pulls: drag lines run from the shoulder into the sleeve, you feel it when you reach.

Why it happens: Broad or muscular shoulders — the pattern's shoulder ends before your shoulder bone.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the armhole at the shoulder only if there is seam allowance: re-stitch the sleeve 0.5 cm into the allowance at the cap. Otherwise choose a sleeveless/raglan style for this garment.
2. Wear-test after; a small ease of the cap makes a big difference.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Slash from mid-shoulder to the armhole notch (L-shape) and spread the armhole outward 1–2 cm / 3/8–3/4 in. Tape paper behind.
2. True the shoulder line and the armhole curve. Repeat on the back. The sleeve stays as it is.

6 Sloping shoulders

What you see: Diagonal drag lines run from the neck down toward the underarm; the armhole area looks loose and collapsed.

Why it happens: Your shoulders slope more than the pattern's; the fabric has nowhere to sit at the shoulder tip.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the sleeve at the top and the shoulder seam at the armhole end. Re-sew the shoulder seam 0.5–1.5 cm / 1/4–5/8 in deeper at the armhole end, tapering to 0 at the neck.
2. Lower the underarm the same amount (scoop the armhole curve) so it doesn't get tight, then reset the sleeve.

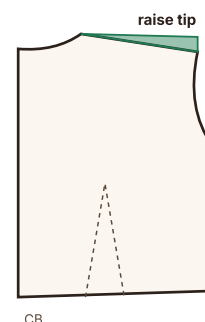
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Lower the shoulder point by the pinned amount on front and back, draw the new shoulder line to the neck point.
2. Lower the armhole bottom by the same amount so the armhole keeps its size.

7 Square shoulders

What you see: Horizontal folds form just below the back collar/neckline; the garment rides up at the side of the neck and sits away at the neck.

Why it happens: Your shoulders are higher/squarer than the pattern's; the fabric is caught on the shoulder tips.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the shoulder seam and sleeve cap. Re-sew the shoulder seam using less seam allowance at the armhole end (0.5–1 cm), tapering to the normal allowance at the neck.
2. If the allowance is not enough, take the same amount deeper at the neck end instead (then trim/lower the neckline).

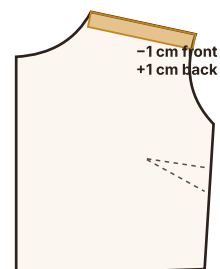
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Raise the shoulder point 0.5–1.5 cm on front and back, draw the new shoulder line to the neck point.
2. Raise the armhole bottom by the same amount so the armhole depth stays the same.

8 Forward shoulder (seam sits behind)

What you see: The shoulder seam slides toward your back; drag lines on the back sleeve cap; the front armhole feels tight.

Why it happens: Rounded shoulders or a forward head posture move your shoulder joint forward of the pattern's seam.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Usually left as is on a finished garment. If it bothers you, unpick the sleeve cap and rotate the sleeve 1 cm toward the front (move the shoulder dot forward), then re-sew.
2. Topstitching or a yoke can visually hide the seam position.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Front: cut a strip 1–1.5 cm / 3/8–5/8 in wide off the shoulder (parallel to the seam).
2. Back: add the same strip to the back shoulder.
The seam moves forward.
3. Move the shoulder dot on the sleeve cap forward by the same amount.

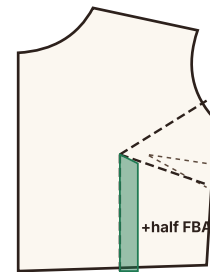
Bust

The single most common adjustment. Patterns are drafted for a B cup unless the pattern says otherwise.

9 Tight across the bust (needs a Full Bust Adjustment)

What you see: Buttons gape between the buttonholes, drag lines point to the bust, the front hem rises, the side seam pulls forward.

Why it happens: Your bust is fuller than the pattern's cup (usually drafted for B). You chose the size by bust, so the shoulders and waist may fit, but the front needs more width and length over the bust.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the side seams at bust level into the allowance (up to 0.5 cm each side).
2. Add a hidden snap or hook between gaping buttons.
3. For the next one, do the Full Bust Adjustment on the paper pattern (right) — it is the real fix.

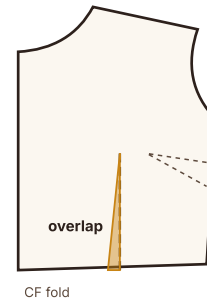
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Choose the size by your UPPER bust (above the bust) + 5 cm / 2 in so the shoulders fit. Mark the bust apex.
2. Draw line 1 from apex down to the waist (parallel to grain), line 2 from apex to the lower third of the armhole, line 3 from apex to the side seam through the dart.
3. Cut line 1 and 2 to the armhole (hinge there), cut line 3 to the apex. Spread line 1 by HALF your extra (e.g. 2.5 cm / 1 in cup difference → 1.2 cm per half-pattern).
4. The side dart opens wider: that's your new dart. Lower the center front hem to level it. True the side seam and waist.

10 Hollow or loose at the bust (needs a Small Bust Adjustment)

What you see: Loose fabric pools at the bust, the dart points to empty space, or vertical folds form between bust and waist.

Why it happens: Your bust is smaller than the pattern's cup; the dart takes up more shaping than you need.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take the side seams in at bust level 0.5–1 cm each, blending to the armhole and waist.
2. Shorten and narrow the bust darts: unpick, re-sew 0.5 cm narrower and 1.5 cm shorter.

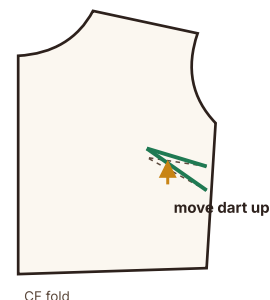
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Same lines as an FBA (apex→waist, apex→armhole, apex→side through the dart), but OVERLAP line 1 by half the difference (e.g. 0.6 cm).
2. The dart closes a little. Raise the center front hem to level it. True the side seam.

11 Bust dart points to the wrong place

What you see: The dart tip sits above, below or beside your bust point; you see a pointy bump or a hollow where the dart ends.

Why it happens: Your bust apex is higher/lower than the pattern's (bust height varies a lot between bodies and bras).



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the dart. Re-draw it with the tip 2–2.5 cm / 3/4–1 in away from your apex (1.5 cm for small cups), then re-sew and press over a ham.

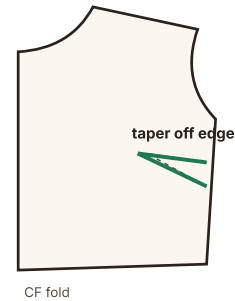
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Mark YOUR apex on the pattern (measure from the shoulder neck point down).
2. Draw a box around the dart, cut it out, slide it up/down to point to the new apex, tape. True the side seam.
3. Tip rule: the dart ends 2–2.5 cm before the apex.

12 Bubble at the dart tip

What you see: The dart ends in a little pointed pucker or 'nipple' instead of fading smoothly.

Why it happens: The dart was sewn with a straight line and a back-stitch at the tip, or pressed flat on the table.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the last 4 cm / 1 1/2 in of the dart. Re-sew so the last 1.5 cm runs almost parallel to the fold, stitching off the edge — no back-stitch.
2. Leave long thread tails and tie a knot. Press over a tailor's ham (or a rolled towel), never flat.

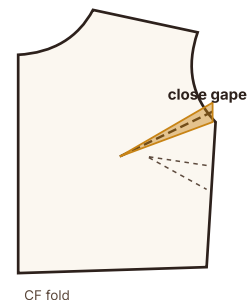
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Redraw the dart legs slightly curved (convex) in the last third so the dart ends tangent to the fold.
2. For a big dart (over 4 cm wide), split it into two smaller darts.

13 Front armhole gapes

What you see: The armhole stands away from your body at the front; you can see into it from the side.

Why it happens: Extra length along the armhole edge — common with a fuller bust or a hollow chest.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Sew an ease-stitch along the armhole edge 3 mm inside the seam, draw up 0.5–1 cm and steam before the binding or sleeve goes on.
2. On a finished sleeveless top: unpick the binding at the front armhole, take a 0.5–1 cm dart pointing to the bust, re-bind.

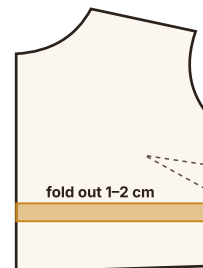
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Pin out the gape as a wedge. On the pattern, slash from the armhole (at the gape) to the apex and overlap by the wedge depth.
2. The excess moves into the bust dart (the dart gets slightly wider). True the armhole curve.

14 Bodice too long — folds above the waist

What you see: Horizontal folds collect just above the waistline; the waist seam sits below your natural waist.

Why it happens: You are short-waisted: your shoulder-to-waist length is shorter than the pattern's.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the waist seam (or skirt), lift the bodice and re-sew it 1–2 cm / 3/8–3/4 in higher; shorten the zipper from the top if needed.
2. Knit tops: take a horizontal tuck inside at the waist, or move the elastic up.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Measure your back waist length (neck bone to waist) and compare with the pattern.
2. Fold a horizontal tuck halfway between the underarm and the waist on front and back (half the difference deep = total difference). True the side seams and darts.

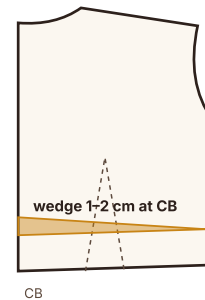
Back

You rarely see your own back — take a photo, or ask someone to pin it for you.

15 Swayback — horizontal folds at the lower back

What you see: Fabric pools in horizontal folds just above your bottom; dresses and skirts lift at the back waist.

Why it happens: Your lower back curves in more than the pattern; the center back is too long between waist and hip.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. On a dress: take a horizontal wedge out of the center back seam at the waist (1–2 cm at CB, 0 at the side), re-sew the zipper.
2. On pants/skirts: lower the back waistband at center back by 1–2 cm, tapering to 0 at the side seams.

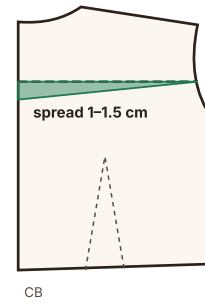
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Draw a horizontal line across the back 5 cm / 2 in below the waist (skirt) or at the waist (dress), from CB to the side seam.
2. Fold out a wedge: 1–2 cm deep at center back, 0 at the side. Straighten the center back line (add a little at the hip).
3. True the darts.

16 Rounded upper back

What you see: The back neckline pulls down and away, the whole garment slides backward, drag lines from the neck to the armholes at the back.

Why it happens: A rounded upper back needs more length at center back between the neck and the shoulder blades.



CB

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Wear a slightly bigger size in knit garments; on wovens add a small back neck dart (0.6–1 cm) to ease the neckline to the new shape if you re-do the collar.

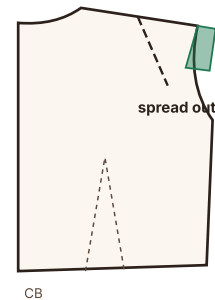
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Cut horizontally across the back 10 cm / 4 in below the neck from CB to the armhole (hinge).
2. Spread 1–1.5 cm at center back, 0 at the armhole. Add a small neck dart or ease to bring the neckline back to size. Straighten CB.

17 Broad back — tight across the shoulder blades

What you see: Pulling across the back when you reach forward; horizontal strain lines between the armholes; back armhole seams pop.

Why it happens: The back is too narrow for your shoulder blades or upper back muscles.



CB

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the back armhole/sleeve seam into the allowance; add a 2 cm action pleat at the center back yoke on shirts.

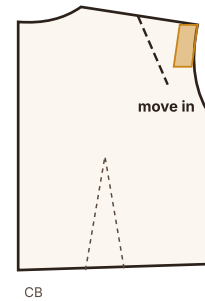
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Slash from mid-shoulder to the back armhole notch (L-shape), spread the armhole outward 0.6–1.5 cm.
2. True the shoulder (take the extra shoulder length out as a small back shoulder dart or ease).

18 Narrow back — vertical folds at the back

What you see: Loose vertical folds between the shoulder blades and the armholes; the back looks baggy while the front fits.

Why it happens: The back is wider than your upper back.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take in the center back seam (if there is one) 0.5–1 cm each side at the upper back, or the side seams at the back armhole.

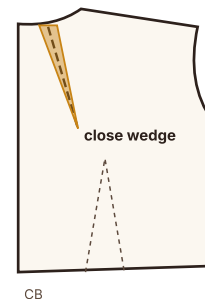
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Slash from mid-shoulder to the back armhole notch (L-shape) and move the armhole inward 0.6–1.5 cm. True the shoulder.

19 Back neckline gapes

What you see: The back neckline stands away from your neck, especially on scoop and V-backs.

Why it happens: Excess length along the back neck edge (common with a rounded upper back or a forward head).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Ease-stitch the back neckline 0.5 cm, or add a small 0.6–1 cm neck dart at each side of center back and re-attach the facing.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Pin the gape out as a wedge; slash from the neckline to the shoulder blade and overlap. Add the removed length as a small back shoulder dart or ease.

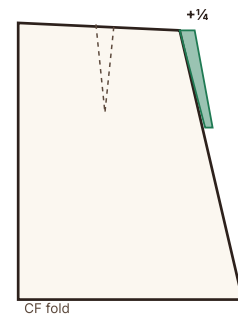
Waist & Hips

Choose skirts and pants by your HIP measurement, then adjust the waist — it's easier than the other way round.

20 Waistband too tight

What you see: The waistband digs in, you get a muffin top, or the button won't close without pulling.

Why it happens: Your waist is bigger than the pattern's size for your hips (very common — waists vary more than hips).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the side seams at the waist 0.5–1 cm each (4 seams = up to 4 cm / 1 1/2 in) and cut a new, longer waistband.
2. Move the button 1–1.5 cm toward the edge for a quick gain.

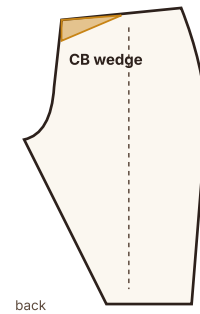
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Add a quarter of the extra at each side seam at the waist (front and back), blending to the hip line.
2. Or make the darts narrower. Lengthen the waistband by the full amount.

21 Waistband gaps at the back

What you see: A gap at center back when you sit or bend; you can put a hand inside the waistband.

Why it happens: A straight waistband on a curvy body (small waist, full hip/seat) or a swayback.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take a wedge out of the back waistband and center back seam: 1–2 cm at CB, 0 at the side. Or thread 2 cm elastic through the back waistband.
2. Add an extra back dart 1 cm wide × 8 cm long each side.

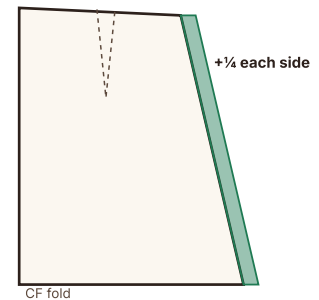
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Use a curved (contour) waistband: cut the straight waistband into 4 sections, fan them out at the bottom edge so the band curves.
2. Deepen the back darts 0.5 cm each or add a CB wedge like a swayback.

22 Tight at the hips — skirt rides up

What you see: The skirt climbs up when you walk, horizontal lines across the hips, the side seams pull forward.

Why it happens: The hip is too small, or the hip curve on the pattern is higher/lower than your fullest hip.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the side seams 0.5–1 cm each over the hip; add a walking slit or open the back vent 5 cm / 2 in higher.

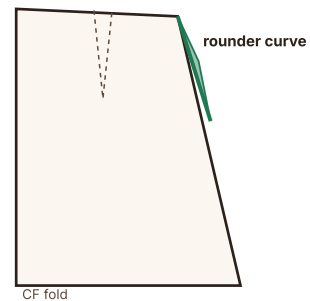
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Add a quarter of the missing ease to each side seam from the waist to the hem (plus 1–2 cm hem width on pencil skirts).
2. Place the hip line where YOUR fullest hip is (measure waist to full hip).

23 'Hip shelf' drag lines

What you see: Diagonal lines from the waist to the side hip; a pocket of fabric sits at the side just below the waist.

Why it happens: The side seam curve doesn't match your hip shape (higher, more rounded hip than the pattern).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Re-sew the side seam with a fuller curve 5–10 cm below the waist (let out 0.5 cm there), keeping the waist the same.

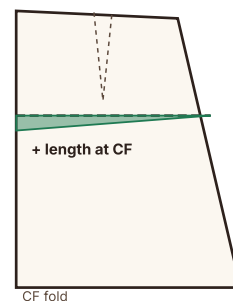
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Redraw the side seam with a rounder curve starting at the waist; use a French curve. Check that the front and back side seams still match in length.

24 Side seams swing forward or back

What you see: The side seam doesn't hang straight down — it pulls toward the front or the back, and the hem tilts.

Why it happens: Uneven balance between front and back: a full tummy or full seat takes more length on one side.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Lift the skirt at the waist on the long side (unpick the waistband and take 0.5–1.5 cm more there), then re-level the hem.

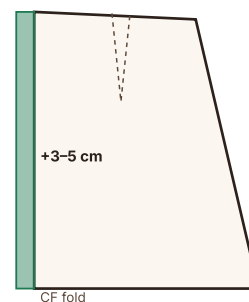
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Add length at the center of the side that needs it (front for tummy, back for seat) by a horizontal slash and spread at the hip, 0 at the side seam.

25 Wrap front gaps or pulls open

What you see: Your wrap dress/skirt opens when you walk or sit; the underlap shows.

Why it happens: Not enough overlap for your hip/bust, or the wrap edge was stretched while sewing.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Add a hidden snap at the waist and at the bust; stabilize the wrap edge with 6 mm stay tape.
2. Move the ties/button 2 cm further to deepen the overlap.

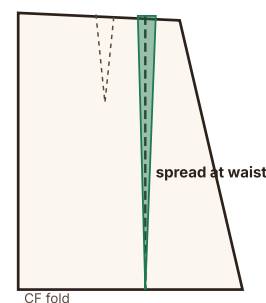
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Extend the wrap edge 3–5 cm / 1 1/4–2 in (parallel to the front edge) for more overlap.
2. Cut the wrap edge on the straight grain when possible; stay-stitch bias edges right after cutting.

26 Full tummy — front hem rises

What you see: The front hem is shorter than the back, diagonal lines from the tummy to the sides; the waistband dips at the front.

Why it happens: The front needs more length and width over the tummy.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Lower the front waistband 1 cm at center front if there is allowance; re-level the hem from the floor.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Slash from the waist (between dart and side) down to the hem and across to the side seam; spread 1–2 cm at the waist.
2. Make the front dart smaller or remove it. Add length at CF waist to level the hem.

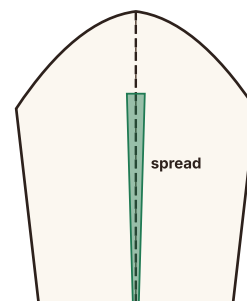
Sleeves & Armholes

Reach forward, lift your arms, hug yourself: sleeves have to move.

27 Sleeve tight in the upper arm

What you see: The sleeve grips your bicep, you see horizontal strain lines, or you can't bend your elbow comfortably.

Why it happens: The bicep width of the pattern is smaller than your upper arm + ease (woven needs 5–7 cm / 2–2 3/4 in ease).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the sleeve seam 0.5 cm into the allowance; cut an underarm gusset (diamond 8 × 12 cm) for a big gain.

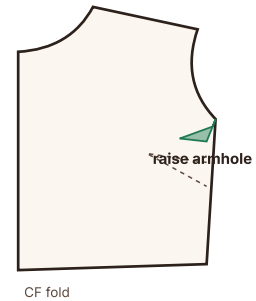
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Draw the center line of the sleeve and a line across at the bicep. Cut the center line to the cap (hinge) and along the bicep line to the seam (hinge).
2. Spread the center 1–4 cm. The cap gets a little lower; the armhole stays the same.

28 Can't lift your arms

What you see: When you raise your arms, the whole garment lifts with them; the waist rides up.

Why it happens: The armhole is too LOW (counter-intuitive): a deep armhole and a low cap restrict movement.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Hard to fix after sewing. You can insert an underarm gusset to gain movement.

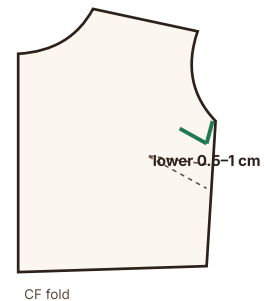
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Raise the armhole bottom 1–2 cm on bodice front and back, and raise the sleeve underarm by the same amount (the sleeve cap gets taller, the sleeve narrower at the top — ease-check it).

29 Armhole cuts in or is too tight

What you see: The armhole digs into your armpit and front; red marks after wearing.

Why it happens: The armhole is too small for your arm or too high.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Scoop the underarm 0.5–1 cm lower (front and back, sleeve the same), clip and re-finish.

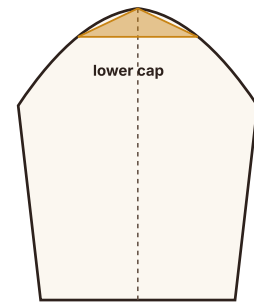
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Lower the armhole 0.5–1 cm at the side seam and scoop the front curve a little; lower the sleeve underarm by the same amount.

30 Puckered sleeve cap

What you see: Small tucks or gathers at the top of a set-in sleeve that should look smooth.

Why it happens: Too much ease in the cap for the fabric (linen, denim and shirting can't ease more than 1.5–2 cm).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the cap. Sew 2 rows of long stitches (4 mm) inside the cap, pull evenly, steam the cap over a ham BEFORE pinning. Sew with the sleeve on the bottom so the feed dog eases it.

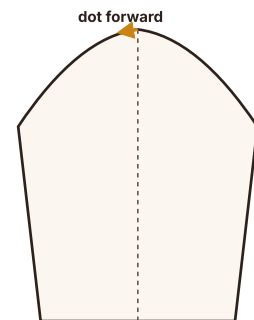
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Measure the cap seam vs. the armhole seam. If the difference is over 2.5 cm, lower the cap 0.5–1 cm (flatten the top), or take a horizontal tuck across the cap.

31 Sleeve twists — drag lines on the sleeve

What you see: Diagonal lines run across the sleeve from the front or back armhole; the sleeve seam spirals.

Why it happens: The sleeve pitch doesn't match your arm (arms hang forward on most people).



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the cap, rotate the sleeve 0.5–1 cm forward (toward the front notch), re-sew.

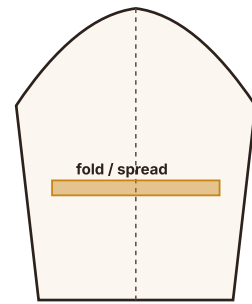
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Move the shoulder dot on the sleeve cap forward 0.5–1 cm; match it to the shoulder seam next time.

32 Sleeves too long or too short

What you see: The hem covers your knuckles or stops above the wrist bone.

Why it happens: Arm length varies more than any size chart.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take the hem up or let down the hem allowance; on cuffs, unpick the cuff, cut the sleeve, re-attach.

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Use the lengthen/shorten line between the bicep and the elbow (most change) and below the elbow; fold or spread evenly, true the seams.

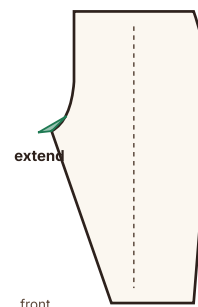
Pants

Always baste the crotch and side seams first and sit, squat and walk in them before final stitching.

33 Front crotch too tight — smile lines

What you see: Curved lines like a smile at the front crotch; pressure in front.

Why it happens: The front crotch curve is too short or too shallow for your front.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Scoop the front crotch curve 0.3–0.6 cm lower at the bottom of the curve, re-sew and trim. Let out the inseam 0.5 cm at the crotch point.

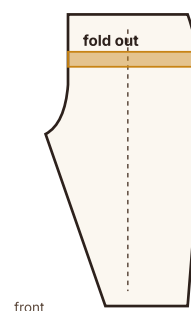
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Extend the front crotch point 0.5–1 cm (lengthen the crotch extension) and scoop the curve slightly. Keep the inseam lengths matching.

34 Crotch too low — frown lines

What you see: Folds hang down from the crotch like a frown; the crotch sits well below your body.

Why it happens: The crotch depth (rise) is too long for you.



front

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take the waistband off and lower the whole pant into it (take 1–2 cm off the top edge), re-attach.

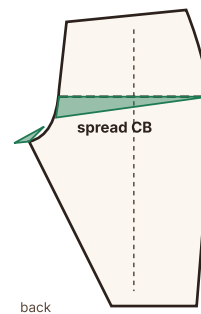
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Measure your crotch depth sitting (waist to chair). Fold a horizontal tuck between the waist and the crotch line on front and back by the difference.

35 Seat too tight — lines under the bottom

What you see: Diagonal lines pointing from the seat to the inner thigh; the back waist pulls down when you sit.

Why it happens: A full seat needs more width and length in the back crotch.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Let out the back inseam 0.5 cm near the crotch; scoop the back crotch curve slightly.

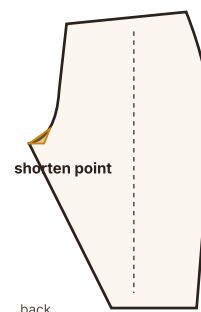
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Slash horizontally at hip level from CB to the side seam (hinge), spread 1–2 cm at CB. Extend the back crotch point 0.5–1.5 cm. True the CB seam.

36 Flat seat — excess under the bottom

What you see: Loose fabric and vertical or diagonal folds under the seat; the back looks baggy.

Why it happens: The back crotch has more room than your seat needs.



Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take in the back inseam 0.5–1 cm near the crotch, blending to 0 at the knee.

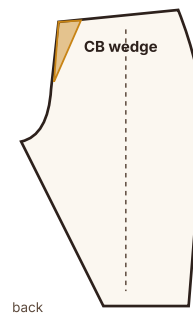
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Shorten the back crotch point 0.5–1 cm and flatten the back crotch curve. Optionally fold a small wedge across the seat at CB.

37 Back waist gaps on pants

What you see: A gap at the back waist when you sit; the pants slide down at the back.

Why it happens: Small waist relative to the seat, or a swayback.



back

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Take a CB wedge out of the back seam and waistband (1–2 cm at the top, 0 at the curve).

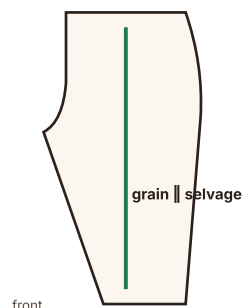
FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Deepen the CB seam at the waist 1–2 cm, blending to the seat curve; shorten the waistband the same. Use a contour waistband.

38 Pant legs twist

What you see: The side seams spiral toward the front or back at the lower leg.

Why it happens: The fabric was cut off-grain, or the front and back legs were stretched differently while sewing.



front

Paper-pattern fix

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the inseam, re-align the legs matching knee notches and re-sew from hem to crotch on both seams (sew in the same direction).

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Check the grainline is parallel to the selvage within 2 mm along its whole length. Pre-wash the fabric and cut single layer for twill/denim.

Hems & Knit Edges

The finishing details that make it look bought, not homemade.

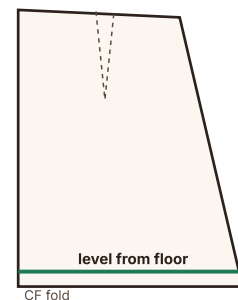
39 Hem is uneven or dips

What you see: The hem looks longer at the sides or front; bias-cut and circle skirts dip in places.

Why it happens: Bias areas stretch over time; a full tummy or seat lifts one side.

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Hang the garment 24 h, then have someone mark the hem from the floor with a ruler (e.g. 45 cm / 17 3/4 in up all around). Trim and re-hem.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Level the hem on the pattern after the balance fixes (swing, tummy, seat). For circle skirts, cut the hem 2 cm longer and mark after hanging.

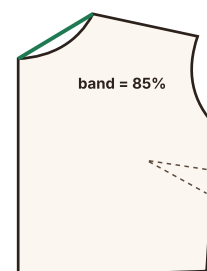
40 Knit neckband is wavy or sticks out

What you see: The neckband ripples, stands up, or doesn't lie flat against your neck.

Why it happens: The band is too long (wavy) or too short (puckers), or the neckline was stretched.

FIX IT ON THE FINISHED GARMENT

1. Unpick the band, cut a new one 85% of the neckline seam length (90% for stable ponte, 75–80% for rib), stretch it evenly using quarter marks, sew with a stretch stitch, then steam.



CF fold

Paper-pattern fix

FIX THE PAPER PATTERN NEXT TIME

1. Measure the neckline seam lines (front + back), multiply by 0.85; band width = 2 × finished + 2 seam allowances (e.g. 2 cm finished → 6 cm cut).